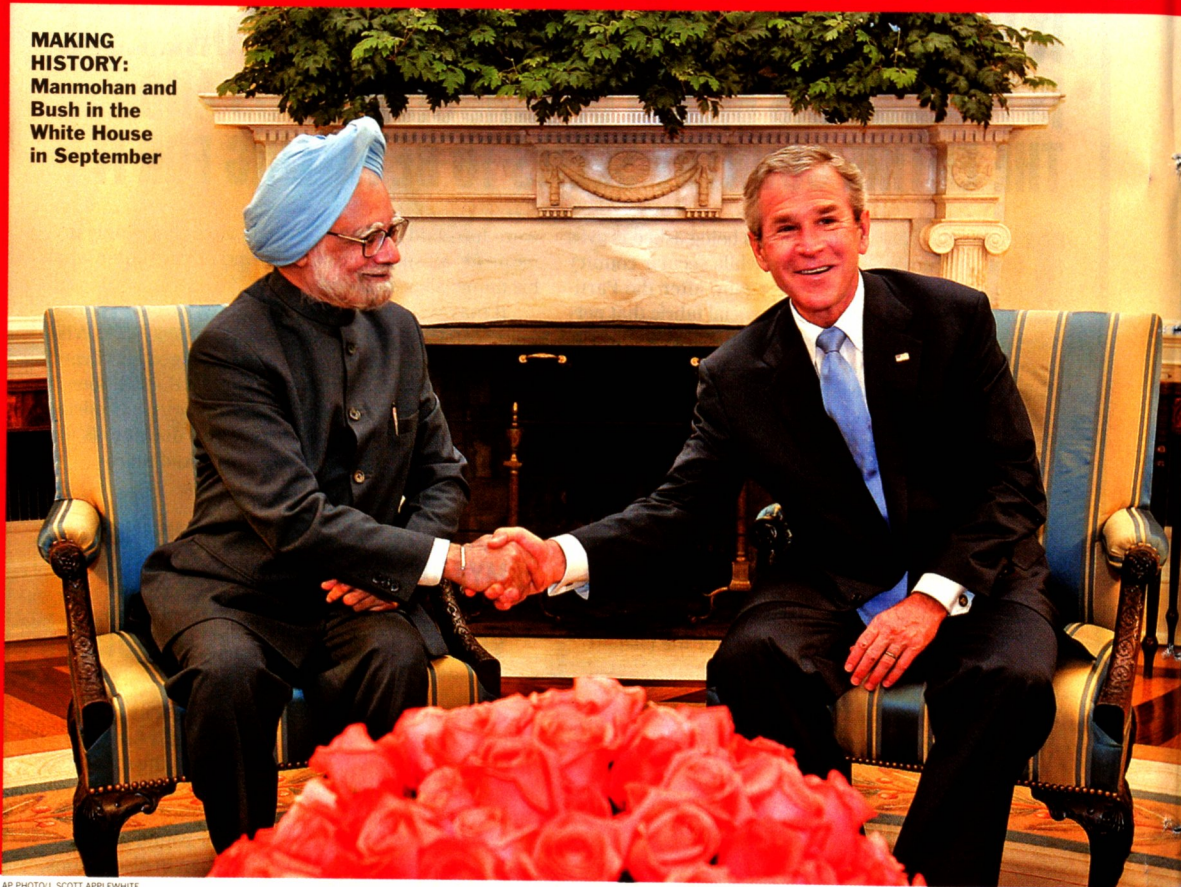


cover story **NUCLEAR DEAL**

THE NEW NUC

MAKING HISTORY:
Manmohan and
Bush in the
White House
in September



AP PHOTO/J. SCOTT APPLEWHITE

■ By Raj Chengappa

As George W. Bush stepped briskly into the White House for the signing ceremony in the afternoon of October 8, the gathering that included Ronen Sen, India's ambassador to the US, was aware that they were witnessing a rare and historic moment. Bush looked much the cat that got the cream as he signed the hard-fought US Congress legislation enabling civilian nuclear trade with India after a hiatus of 34 long years. He had plenty of reason to look pleased. Even as the walls of the US economy seemed to be crumbling around him, he was ending his two-term tenure as President with a signal foreign policy success—a bright ray of sunshine amid the gathering gloom. In India it was just past the midnight hour and as the

country slept, its giant nuclear establishment, to paraphrase Jawaharlal Nehru, was stepping out from the old to the new and waking up to new life and freedom. As a senior Indian diplomat observed, "We're out of the doghouse and on the high road again."

For years after India's 1974 nuclear test, the country was treated like a pariah, especially by the US. America had erected an entire architecture of laws and multinational groupings meant to isolate and punish India for being a rogue nuclear power. Sanctions were